13. Public Opinion

Breakout Sessions

POLS 1101

8:40am-9:35am Baldwin 322

& 9:55am-10:50am Journalism 509

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Public Opinion and Democracy

- **Majoritarianism**: A majority of the people holds **clear, consistent opinions** on government policy. The government should act as it is expected.

- **Pluralism**: The public as a whole **seldom** demonstrates clear, consistent opinion. The government should allow free expression from the minorities.
  - Opinion polls -> **Is it accurate?**
    - How the sample is selected (random sample is better)
    - **SOME FACTORS THAT CAN BIAS A SURVEY (SEE SLIDES)**
    - The amount of variation in the population **(greater / less variation?)**
    - The size of the sample (larger sample is better, but **NOT DECISIVE**)
  - E.g. If we wish to know people's ideology distribution through observing what they posted on *X* (Twitter), what are the advantages and disadvantages?

How People Form Their Opinions

- **Political socialization**
  - Family (**transmission model**)
  - School (social order -> civic education -> more critical thinking)
  - Community & peers (homogeneity; "information bubble" as the result of self selection)
  - Continuing socialization (workplace environment; **mass media**)

- **Other predictors of public opinion**
  - Education, income, region, ethnicity, race, religion, gender… ("SES")
  - Political knowledge
    - https://www.pewresearch.org/politics/quiz/what-do-you-know-about-the-u-s-government/
  - Cost-benefit analysis based on self-interest
    - By contrast, "National interest" may matter – **"sociotropic responses"**: how well the country, as a whole, works can affect political preferences more strongly than one's own personal circumstance.
  - Political leadership **(by issue priming & framing)**

How Public Opinion Shapes Policy Decisions

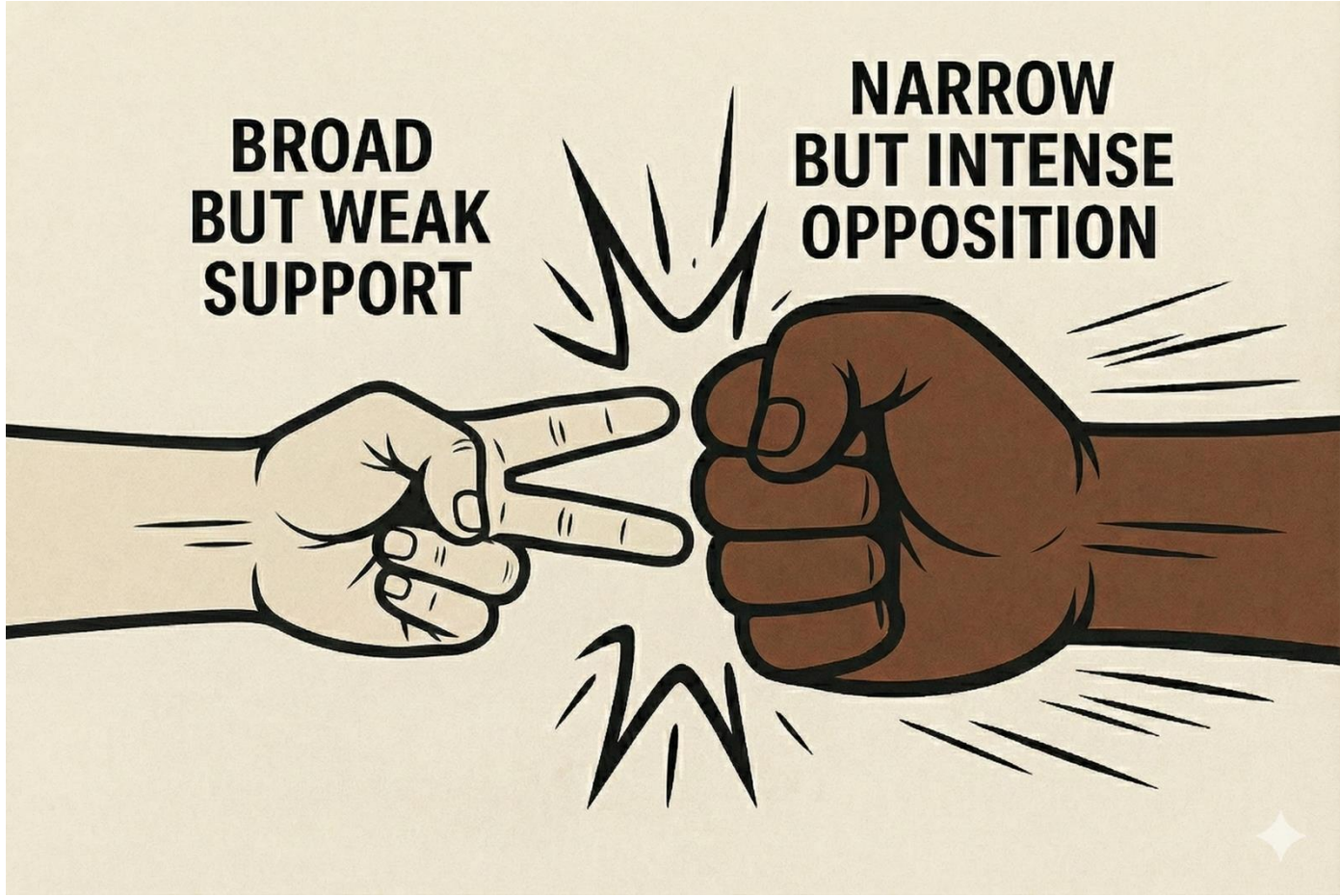
- Policies often fail not because too few people support them, but because a smaller group strongly oppose them.

Broad but Weak Support (free-rider)

- Many people say “sounds good”
- Low salience
- Little time, money, or organization
- Limited participation

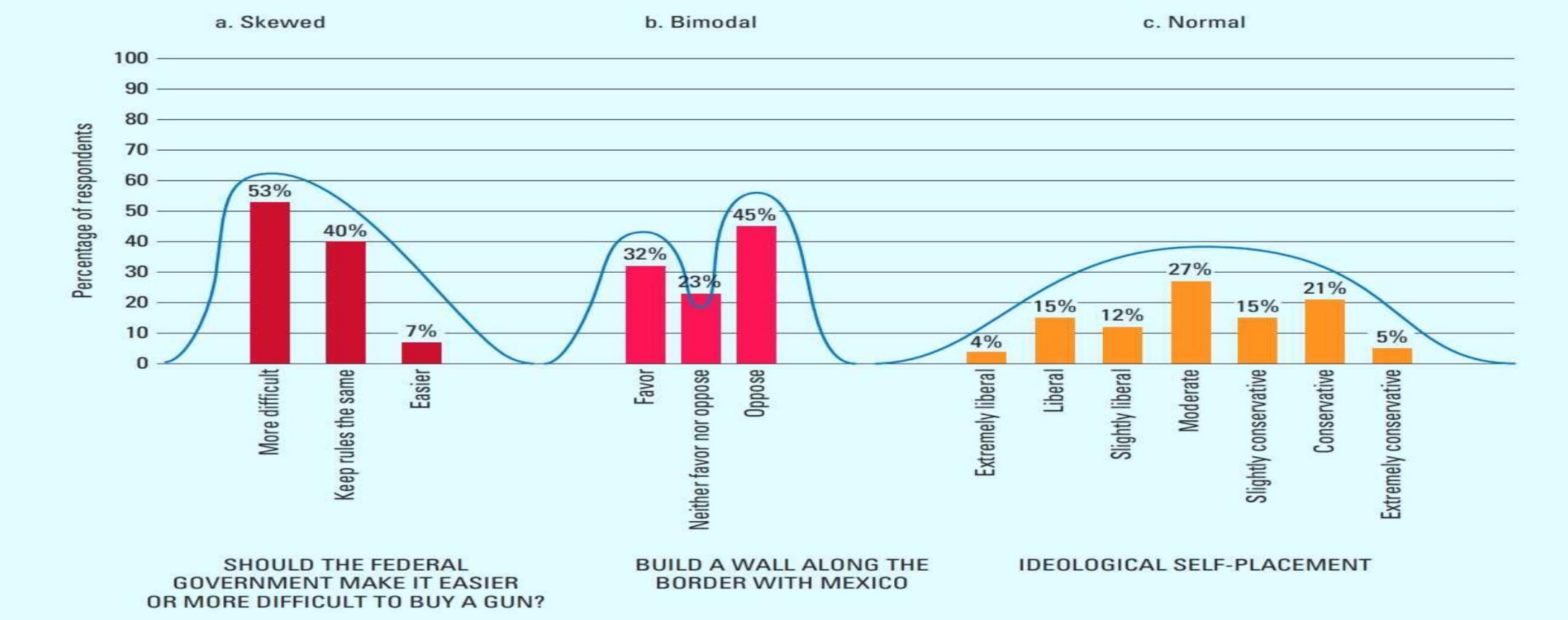
Narrow but Intense Opposition (coalition)

- Fewer people, but highly affected
- High salience
- Strong incentives to mobilize
- Organized, vocal, persistent



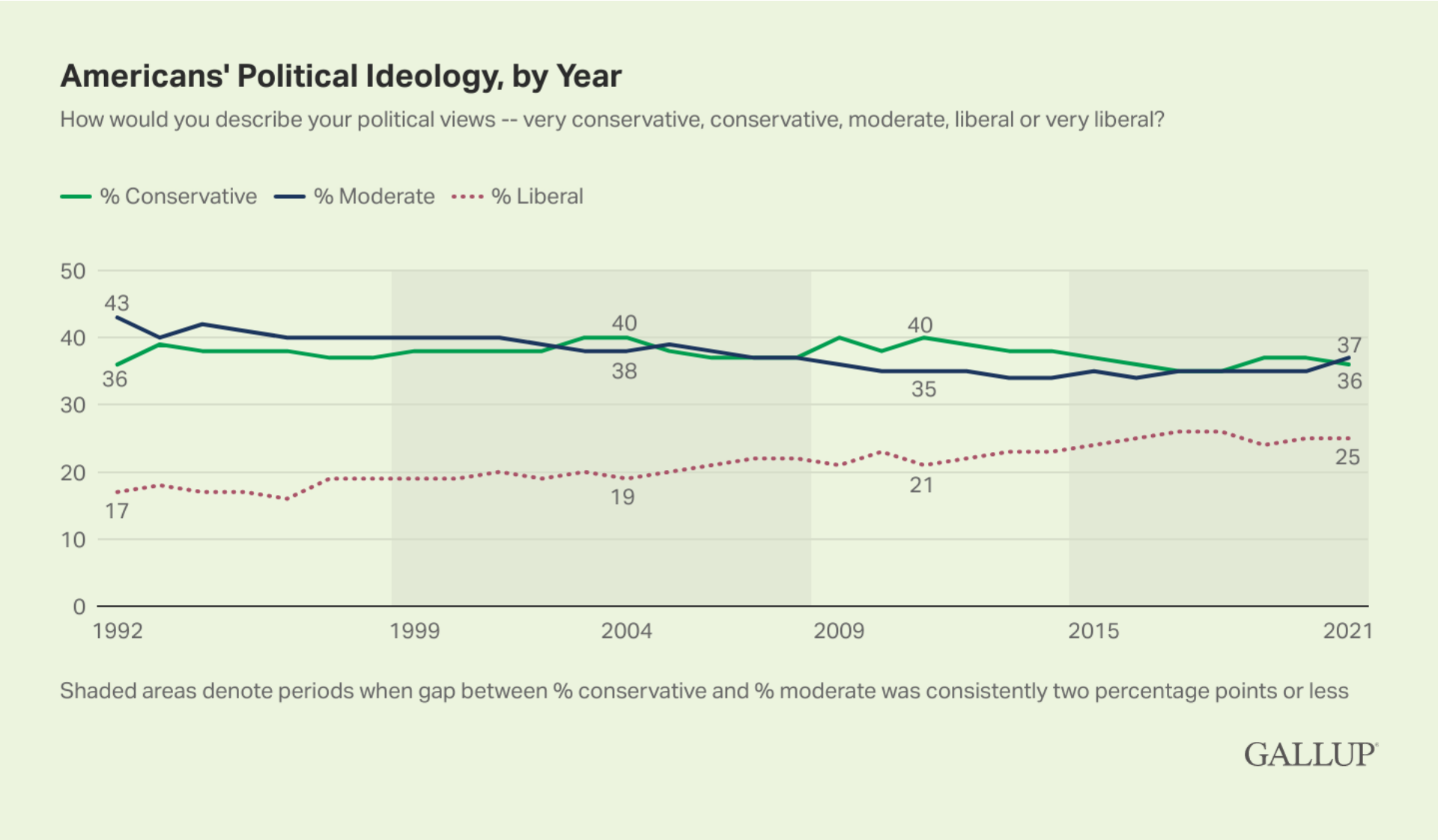
Public Opinion Distribution

- Shape of the opinion distribution, and its political implications
  - **Normal distribution** -> moderate government policy
  - **Skewed distribution** -> a high level of consensus, but may overlook minorities
  - **Bimodal distribution** -> political conflict



Public Opinion Distribution (cont`d)

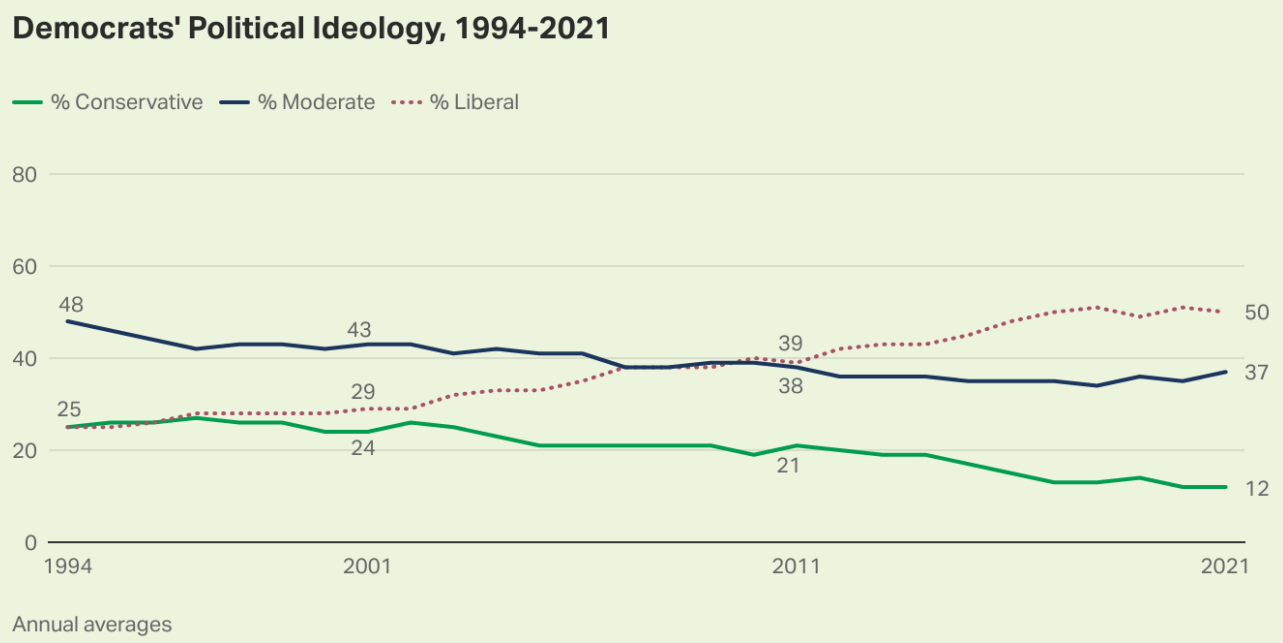
- **A stable distribution**: opinions show little change over time.
- However, even the most enduring ideological labels were not always this way.
  - **Abortion**
    - *In the early years, there was much more ambiguity*: both parties had factions for and against abortion, and public opinion was not strongly split along party lines. (Biden was against the abortion when he was newly elected as a senator!)
    - After the 1973 *Roe v. Wade* decision legalized abortion nationwide, conservative religious movements and Republican strategists turned abortion into a central cultural and electoral issue, while Democrats increasingly aligned with abortion-rights advocates.
    - Politicians choose sides, and voters follow. Now it's one of the most partisan-related issues in U.S.
  - **Same-sex marriage**
    - It gained more public approval in the past years (driven in part by President Trump's general acceptance of it, so that Republican Congress members could vote for their own view).
    - After *Dobbs v. Jackson Women's Health Organization*, things may change…
  - **Public opinion can evolve under the impact of politics, even turn to the opposite position! ("changing definitions of a problem" – framing effect)**



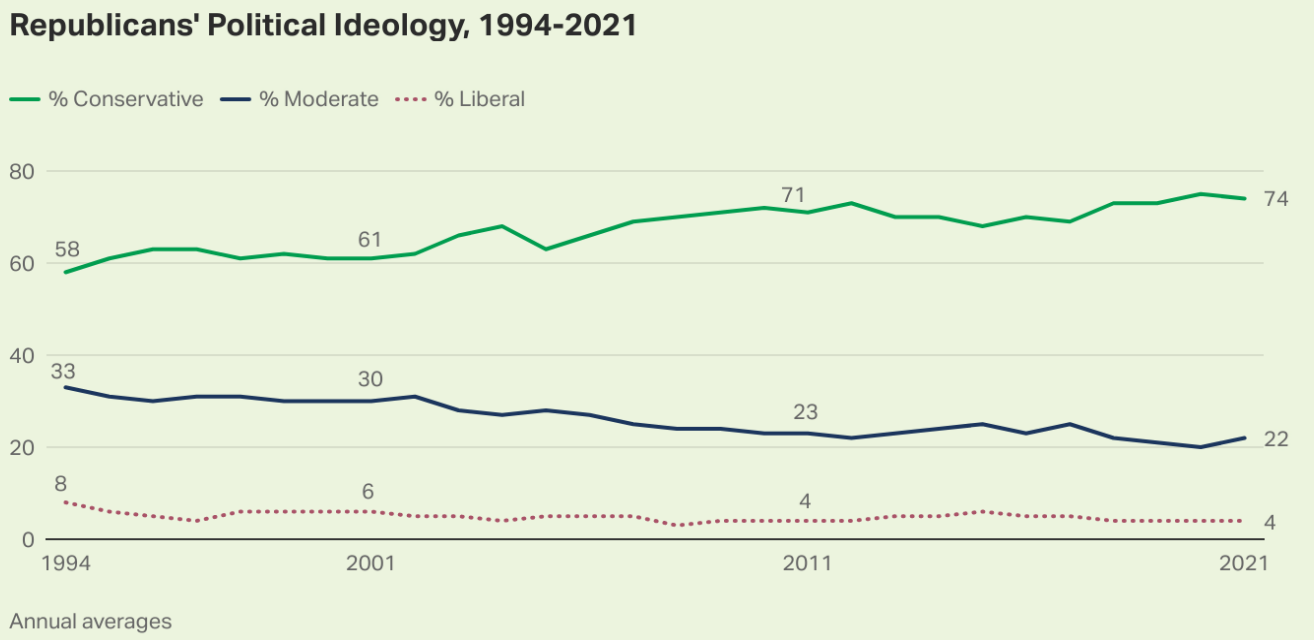
1. Which of the three ideological labels shows the greatest change in the past decades?

2. Whenever there are major political events (such as economic crises, elections, or social movements), are there any short-term fluctuations in these labels?

Source: https://news.gallup.com/poll/388988/political-ideology-steady-conservatives-moderates-tie.aspx?utm_source=chatgpt.com



- ✓ **What do you find?**
- ✓ **Are there any fun and/or important facts?**



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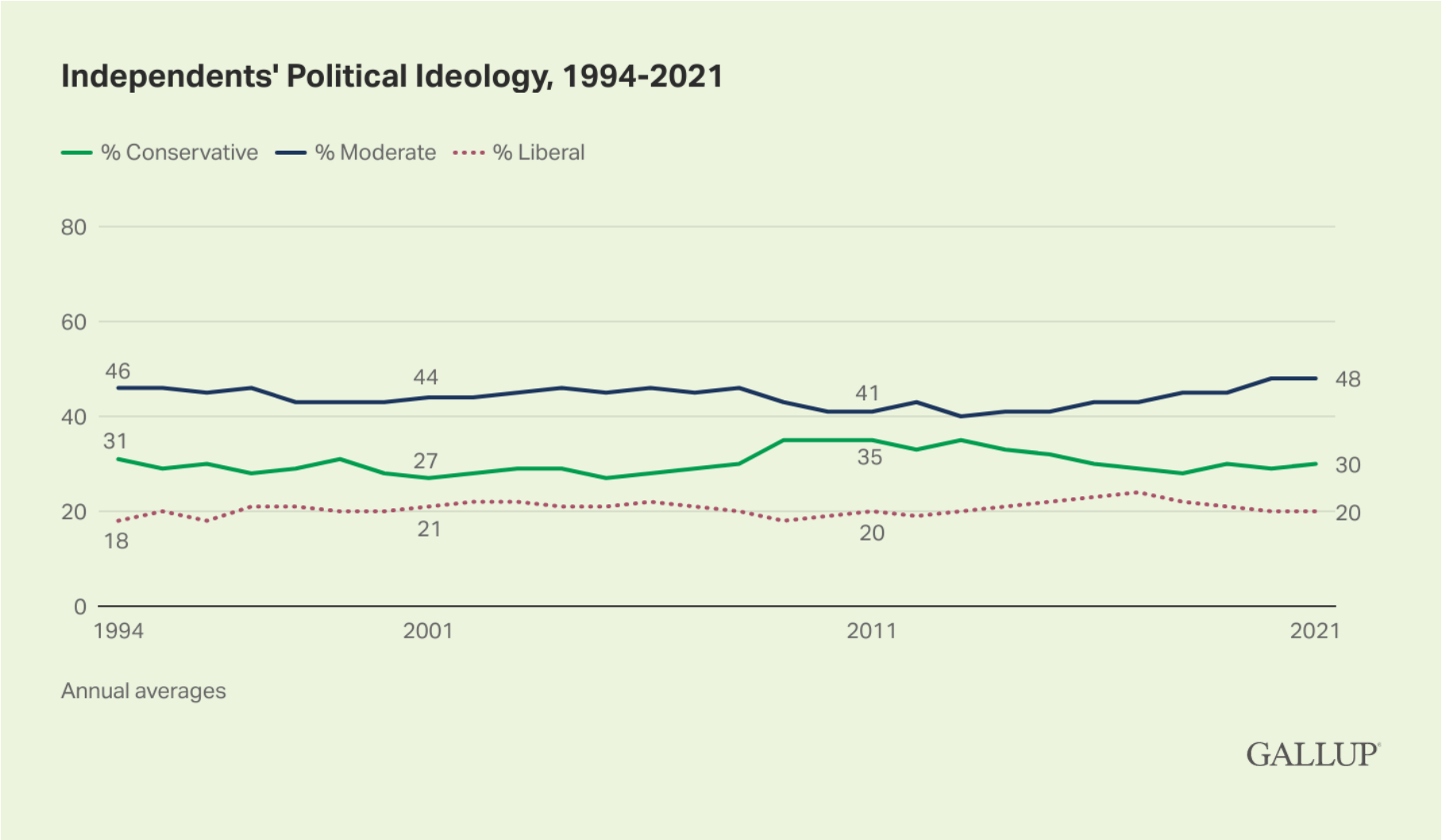

Party identification is not equal to ideologies.

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Americans' Political Ideology by Subgroup, 2021

	Conservative	Moderate	Liberal
	%	%	%
U.S. adults	36	37	25
Gender			
Men	41	37	20
Women	32	37	29
Age			
18 to 29	23	41	34
30 to 49	33	40	25
50 to 64	43	36	19
65+	45	32	21
Education			
Postgraduate	27	36	36
College graduate only	31	38	30
Some college	38	39	22
No college	42	37	19
Household income			
$100,000 or more	36	38	26
$40,000 to <$100,000	37	38	25
Less than $40,000	35	39	25
Race/Ethnicity			
Non-Hispanic White adults	42	34	23
Non-Hispanic Black adults	20	51	26
Hispanic adults	31	38	28
Region			
East	31	39	29
Midwest	37	37	24
South	42	36	19
West	32	38	28
Party ID			
Republicans	74	22	4
Independents	30	48	20
Democrats	12	37	50

Based on combined monthly data from January to December 2021

GALLUP,

- ✓ **What do you find?**
- ✓ **Are there any fun and/or important facts?**

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Next week…

- Read materials on **Participation & Voting** before class, and that will be helpful to participate in peer discussions.
- Feel free to email me if you have any questions!
- ENJOY YOUR WEEKEND!